

ARCTIC OCEAN

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ONE OF THE COLDEST places on Earth, the Arctic Ocean is surrounded by the northern parts of Europe, Asia, North America, and Greenland. These icy lands are rich in minerals and wildlife, but are home to few people. In summer, when temperatures reach 0°C (32°F), warm currents from the Pacific and Atlantic melt some of the ice. With the help of icebreakers to clear their path, ships are able to sail along the coasts of Asia and North America.

Physical features

The Arctic is the smallest and shallowest of the world's oceans. Most of its surface is covered by a frozen mass of floating ice about 2 m (6 ft) thick. The North Pole lies in the centre of the Arctic Ocean on drifting pack ice.

ARCTIC OCEAN FACTS

AREA	14,089,600 sq km (5,440,000 sq miles)
AVERAGE DEPTH	1,330 m (4,360 ft)
AVERAGE ICE THICKNESS	1.5–3 m (4.9–9.8 ft)
LOWEST TEMPERATURE	-70°C (-94°F) on northeast tip of Greenland



Icebergs

Giant icebergs break off glaciers in Greenland and drift south into the North Atlantic Ocean. They rise up to 120 m (400 ft) above sea-level. As only a fraction of an iceberg shows above water, they are a shipping hazard.

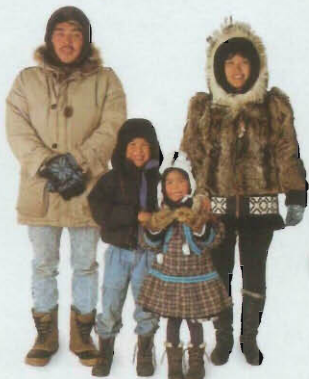


Northern lights

On dark nights, spectacular coloured lights, or Aurora, can be seen in the sky. Caused by electricity in the upper atmosphere, they are brightest in mid winter when the sun never rises and invisible in summer due to 24-hour sun.

Arctic peoples

About 800,000 indigenous people live in the Arctic. The Yu'pik of Alaska are part of the Eskimo group that includes Inuit in Canada and Greenland and Yuit in Siberia. Many have given up nomadic life and now live in villages. The Arctic is the workplace of about 2,000,000 engineers and traders from the south.



Yu'pik family from Alaska



Greenland

Although Greenland is the world's largest island, its permanent ice cover means few people live there. The most populated area is the southwest coast, where the climate is less extreme than the bleak centre. The island is a self-governing territory of Denmark.



Halibut



Haddock



Cod

GREENLAND FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Nuuk (Godthaab)
AREA	2,175,600 sq km (840,000 sq miles)
POPULATION	56,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Danish, Greenlandic
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Danish krone

Fishing

Cod, haddock, halibut, and shrimp fishing are the mainstay of Greenland's economy. Fish-processing factories freeze and can the fish for export to Europe and the USA. Much of the cod is made into fish fingers.

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